19.4 Joints

The point at which two separate bones meet is called a joint. Depending on the type of movement they allow, joints can be of three types: fixed, slightly movable and movable joints.

19.4.1 Fixed or Immovable joints

In this type of joint no movement is possible between the two bones. The structures between the bones of the skull box are examples of immoveable joints.

19.4.2 Slightly movable joints

Here, only very little (partial) movement occurs between the two bones. The joint between a rib and the breast bone or between the vertebrae is the example for slightly movable joint.

DO YOU KNOW?

Joints are the place where two bones meet or connect. Ligaments are short bands of tough fibrous connective tissues that function to connect one bone to another, forming the joint.Tendons are made of elastic tissues and they also play a key role in the functioning of joints.

19.4.3 Freely movable joints

In this type, varying degree of movements is possible between the two bones forming the joint. There are six major types of movable joints. They are given below in Table 19.2.

Table 19.2 Types of movable joints.

Joint	Examples	Description	Mobility
Ball and Socket	Shoulder Hip	A ball shaped head of one bone articulates with a cup like socket of an adjacent bone.	Movement can occur in three planes. This joint allows the greatest range of movement.
Hinge	Elbow, Knee, Ankle	A cylindrical protrusion of one bone articulates with a trough-shaped depression of an adjacent bone.	Movement is restricted to one plane. This joint allows bending and straightening only.
Pivot	Spine (Atlas / Axis joint at the top)	A rounded or pointed structure of one bone articulates with a ring-shaped structure of Radius Ulna- an adjacent bone.	Movement is restricted to one plane. This joint allows rotation about its longitudinal axis only.
Condyloid	Wrist	Similar to a ball and socket joint but with much flatter articulating surfaces forming a much shallower joint.	Movement can occur in two planes. This joint allows the second greatest range of movement.
Gliding	Spine (between the bony processes of the vertebrae)	Articulating surfaces are almost flat and of a similar size.	Gliding allows movement in three planes, but it is severely limited.
Saddle	Thumb, shoulder and inner ear.	One part is concave (turned inward) at one end and looks like a **saddle.** The other end is convex (turned outward), and looks like a rider in a **saddle.**	Flexion-extension and abduction-adduction movements are seen

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